thirst.

This paradox, of an increasingly powerful man shaken by the realization of his innate fragility, would become a propelling force of Akbar's destiny; driving him now, in Gujarat, to the cusp of legend and the brink of insanity.

Surely there is something manic, for example, about Akbar's pursuit of Mirza Ibrahim.

It began as a relatively unhurried march towards Broach, where the Mirza had fled. Akbar even stopped in Cambay en route for his first-ever sight of the sea. The padishah had reached Baroda when he heard that Ibrahim had left Broach and passed within a few kilometres of the imperial camp.

Akbar was incensed at the Mirza's temerity. How dare he come so close to Akbar's army, like a wild ass scampering past a pride of lions, and presume they wouldn't catch him? Akbar leapt on a horse and galloped after Ibrahim that very night.

Badauni says he took only four men with him, leaving word for reinforcements to follow; Abul Fazl says ten, each of whom was allowed no more than two accompanying soldiers. At any rate, it was a small party – much smaller than Ibrahim's 1000 troops[21] – and when, the following day at dusk, they reached the outskirts of a small town called Sarnal, where Ibrahim had camped for the night, it was quite rational if 'the Emperor's followers endeavoured to conceal themselves'.[22]

Their lord, however, was intent on charging in. He would not wait for reinforcements, nor even for darkness to disguise the approach of their small number – only forty-odd men, writes Abul Fazl. A night attack, he declared, was 'a form of deception and fraud'. Instead, standing upon a low hill above Sarnal, Akbar began to put on his armour.

Just then, a gallop of horses: reinforcements had arrived! But Akbar would not have them. 'We'll not suffer them to share in the fight with us.'[23]

Why? They were late, he said.

The unfortunate platoon – which included Raja Bhagwant Das and, for his first prominent role in Mughal chronicles, a young Man Singh – had been on their way to Surat when Akbar recalled them; they had travelled a longer distance than Akbar to get here, and arrived not too far behind their emperor. But no. Akbar denounced their delay; if they had so little appetite for battle, why should they have any part in it? The men had to beg to be